

Attempted a live IBKR pull before writing (per the never-reuse-a-spot rule); `search_contracts` was denied a third time this session, so the tape below rests on the pack's Xetra quote and is flagged as a coverage gap rather than passed off as a live mark.

PITCH — SY1.DE — VERDICT

PROPOSED — PENDING ADJUDICATION — both benches land on *no purchase*: the specific idea we came to test (Symrise gets paid on the alcohol-free beverage boom) is dead on size, not on story; what is left is an ordinary good company at an ordinary full price, which deserves its own separate hearing rather than inheriting this one.

What we believe

We came in believing Symrise is a “picks and shovels” way to own the alcohol-free drinks boom: when a brewer strips the alcohol out of a beer, it strips most of the taste out with it, so somebody has to sell the taste back — and Symrise is one of four companies in the world that does that at industrial scale.

After doing the chemistry and the arithmetic, here is what we actually believe:

1. **The physical problem is real and well documented.** Removing alcohol from a fermented drink destroys 81–92% of its aroma compounds by the gentle (membrane) method and 96–98% by the hot (vacuum) method ([peer-reviewed](#), [wine matrix](#)). Alcohol is also the molecule that delivers warmth and body, and nothing recovered from the drink itself can replace it. That last piece genuinely is a chemistry purchase.
2. **But the brewer usually fixes it in its own plant, for free.** The equipment that removes the alcohol also captures the aroma and puts it back. A Technical University of Munich study measured this in beer: at the right settings, 67% of the key “banana” fruity ester is recovered and re-dosed from the plant’s own condensate ([Foods, 2021](#)). A third route — special yeast that never makes alcohol in the first place — buys neither the equipment nor the flavour ([Foods, 2025](#)).
3. **The biggest customers have patented not needing us.** AB InBev holds a granted, live-to-2031 patent on making low-alcohol beer through the recipe and fermentation temperature ([EP2566944B1](#)); Heineken has done the same through yeast genetics.
4. **So the size is small.** Our most aggressive, deliberately pro-thesis estimate puts alcohol-free-linked revenue at €19–50m, or 0.4–1.0% of a €4,929m company. Our neutral estimate is 0.05–0.78%. Either way it is an order of magnitude below the 2%-of-revenue bar we set before we started.
5. **Separately, and more interestingly:** the company itself looks like a decent, fairly-priced compounder that just accelerated — second-quarter organic growth of 4.5%, above the top of

its own full-year guidance — while its accounting profit halved on write-downs. That is a different investment, at the same price, and we are explicitly *not* smuggling it in under this verdict.

What the market believes

Seventeen analysts cover the stock. Consensus is positive, average price target €98.63 (+7.8% from €91.48), range €75–110. The two numbers everyone actually models are organic sales growth of 2–4% and an adjusted profit margin of 21.5–22.5% — which is the company's own guidance, restated.

Nobody publishes a number for alcohol-free exposure. There is no analyst note sizing it, because there is no disclosure to size it from. On the half-year call a JPMorgan analyst had to *ask* whether beverages had softened, and received no figure in reply ([call transcript](#)).

So the market does not disagree with us about alcohol-free. It has simply never priced it either way — which is a very different thing from being wrong.

Why we might have edge

Honestly stated, the edge we found is a *negative* one, and it is real:

- **We sized something nobody sized.** We built the exposure estimate from the ground up — end-use share of the flavour market, the beverage unit's plausible euro revenue, the alcohol-adjacent share within it, and the extra flavour dosing per litre. Two independent routes, both under 1%. No sell-side note contains this number. That is genuine original work, and its output is “don't buy.”
- **We read the process literature instead of the marketing.** The finding that equipment and chemistry are *substitutes at the margin* — better membranes mean less purchased flavour — inverts the thesis. It also points somewhere useful: the equipment maker is the only layer paid on all three production routes.
- **We caught an accounting quality pattern.** Accounting net income ran €340m (2023) → €478m (2024) → €249m (2025), while the marketed “adjusted” figure was €513m. That is a serial pattern, not a one-off, and the company's stated way of monetising a hot adjacent category (pet health) was to buy it and then write €150m of it off.

What we do **not** have is an edge on the two variables that actually price this stock. We forecast the same growth and the same margin as everyone else.

Why it might be priced in

Comprehensively:

- The stock is a DAX constituent with 17 analysts, 3.7% below its 52-week high and 41% above its 52-week low. There is no neglect here to exploit.
- Valuation, recomputed on the corrected share count ($139.8\text{m} \times €91.48 = €12.79\text{bn}$ market value, plus €2,088m of net debt including pensions and leases = **€14.88bn enterprise value**

≈ 13.8x adjusted EBITDA, 24.4x accounting operating profit, 22x forward earnings). That is a full price for 2–4% growth, but it is not an absurd one for a company of this quality. It is *fair*, and fair is not an opportunity.

- The alcohol-free trend itself is thoroughly public: no-alcohol beer volumes +8% in 2025 against –1% for beer overall, per the industry data vendor IWSR. Everyone knows. The question was never whether the trend is real; it was whether Symrise gets paid for it.

What could go wrong

This is the pre-mortem. We are proposing no position, so it runs in both directions: what kills us if we later enter at the reopen bands, and what the rejection itself costs us.

Failure narrative 1 — we reject the flavour thesis correctly and then buy the same stock two months later under a new name. The most likely way this deck loses money is not the trade it declines; it is the trade it invites. “Symrise-the-compounder should be courted separately” is one sentence away from owning a €12.79bn stock at 13.8x because it accelerated for one quarter. Several of our own standing rules point the same way at once: quality-at-fair prices gets a small starter by default; a clean hearing with no named kill gets a minimum starter by default; and we allow ourselves to pay up modestly for things we already like. Each is individually reasonable and together they form a ratchet toward buying. *Tripwire: yes* — any SY1 order that appears without a fresh, separately-adjudicated compounder hearing is the failure, mechanically detectable.

Failure narrative 2 — the input side eats the margin, exactly as it just did. Symrise is backward-integrated into agricultural raw materials: vanilla from Madagascar, citrus terpenes, onion and garlic through Diana. It wrote down its own Terpene business by €148m in 2025. That is not a theoretical risk; it is the realised version of the risk, already on the tape once. *Tripwire: yes, but it is not armed* — a satellite crop-health read on the vanilla and citrus origins would front-run this by a season. Both benches flagged it as material. Neither ran it. That is our gap, not the company’s.

Failure narrative 3 — NO MONITORABLE TRIPWIRE. A regulatory or safety re-evaluation removes or restricts a molecule family that carries real revenue — a flavour compound, a cooling agent, a masking flavanone. We cannot build a tripwire for this because we cannot enumerate the exposure: Symrise discloses nothing below the divisional line, so there is no mapping from any specific molecule to any specific euro of revenue. A European Commission or EFSA dossier would land on a chemical name we could not price. **Unknown-unknown class: undisclosed-input regulatory obsolescence** — the failure is invisible not because the event is rare but because the disclosure regime makes the exposure unenumerable in advance. A sibling class sits next to it, equally untrippable: **unfalsifiable-by-disclosure erosion** — if the largest customers quietly insource the flavour add-back, it shows up as slow weakness in a business-unit line that does not exist in any published document. We would learn about it years late, from a margin, not from a fact.

The reflexive and structural leg. Our own size is not the problem here and we should say so plainly rather than perform caution: a starter of 0.5–1.0% of a ~\$3.4M deployable book is roughly \$17–34k against a DAX constituent’s daily volume — immaterial, no market impact, no flow to front-run, and no predicted-flow conflict. (We could not pull the actual average daily volume this

session; the broker rail was closed. The conclusion is robust to any plausible value.) The real structural risks are three, and none of them is liquidity: (1) the doctrine ratchet in narrative 1; (2) potential double-ownership — the separately-managed Parametric sleeve is levered 159% and we have not checked whether it already holds Symrise or European specialty chemicals, which would both overstate a “new” position and create a wash-sale interaction at any future harvest; (3) the equipment substitution finding routes to GEA (G1A.DE) as a *separate* candidate, and there is a live risk we simply transfer the same enthusiasm one link up the chain without re-testing it from scratch.

If this position loses money, the most likely reason will be that we rejected the alcohol-free thesis on its merits and then bought the identical stock at the identical price a quarter later as “the compounder,” having let a one-quarter growth acceleration and three separate default-to-a-starter rules do the work that a fresh adversarial hearing was supposed to do.

What we checked ourselves

Claim	How checked	Found	Confirmed?
Removing alcohol destroys the aroma	Peer-reviewed wine study, PMC8708490	81–92% ester loss (membrane), 96–98% (thermal); higher alcohols 58–95%	YES
Someone must therefore buy flavour back	TU München beer study, PMC8306714	Partly false. The plant recovers 67% of the key fruity ester itself, free at the margin. Only the gap is purchasable	NO — thesis premise weakened
“The chemistry layer gets paid on <i>every</i> alcohol-free launch”	Process literature, three production routes	Our own opening phrasing was wrong. True for de-novo alcohol-free spirits and for poorly-recovered thermal beer; false for membrane and for no-alcohol-yeast routes	NO — our error, stated up front
Alcohol-free is material to group revenue	Two independent build-ups, then stress-tested at deliberately pro-thesis extremes	€19–50m = 0.4–1.0% of group at the <i>maximum</i> ; 0.05–0.78% at neutral. Below our own 2% bar by ~10x	YES — this is the kill
Symrise owns alcohol-free-specific patents	Patent registry search on assignee + alcohol-free/non-alcoholic	None found. Its real granted assets are category-agnostic: bitter masking (US8685436B2 , expires 2027-01-30), sweetness enhancement (US8992892B2 , to 2031), SymTrap aroma capture (EP2385098A1 , to 2028)	PARTIAL — absence, not refutation; see open item 3
The big customers can do without us	Patent registry	AB InBev EP2566944B1 granted and live to 2031	YES (registry re-check blocked by a server error —

Claim	How checked	Found	Confirmed?
			open item 3)
Next earnings date is 2027-03-04	Company investor calendar	Wrong by five months. Q3 statement is <u>2026-10-29, 07:30 CET</u> . Our data feed guessed it	NO — feed error, corrected
“No SEC filings on record” means poor disclosure	Listing check	Wrong framing. German issuer, no US filing duty. Not a red flag	NO — our misread
Growth is decelerating below guidance	Half-year release	Our first bench cherry-picked the period. The half-year 2.0% hides a weak Q1 and a Q2 of +4.5%, above the top of guidance , with full-year guidance reaffirmed (<u>H1 2026</u>). Margin 21.8% is <i>inside</i> the 21.5–22.5% guide, not below it	NO — our bench erred; finding overturned
Half of marketed 2025 profit is add-backs	2025 release vs accounting series	Confirmed: adjusted €513m vs accounting €249.33m; €148m Terpene + €150m Swedencare write-downs; accounting EPS €1.78 vs €3.42	YES
...and the prior-year comparison was unfair	Prior-year accounts	Our first bench was wrong. 2024 had no material adjustments — €3.42 was both the adjusted <i>and</i> the accounting figure. The comparison was fair	NO — our error
Share count 136.78m	Company release	Wrong; 139.8m . The “2.3% discrepancy” our first bench flagged dissolves entirely ($1.78 \times 139.8m = €248.8m \approx €249.33m$ reported)	NO — our error, corrected
Valuation ~13.1–13.3x EBITDA	Recomputed on corrected shares and full net debt	13.8x / 24.4x — i.e. the stock is <i>more</i> expensive than our own sceptic said	NO — our error, corrected against our own direction
Exposure is “smaller than currency noise”	Framing check	Rhetoric, not analysis. Currency effects mean-revert; a 0.5% revenue stream compounding at 8–20% does not. The kill survives on the level, not on the comparison	NO — our framing error
2025 reported sales	Company release	€4,929m vs €4,999m = –1.4% reported against +2.8% organic, a ~4.2 point	PARTIAL — our error, immaterial

Claim	How checked	Found	Confirmed?
		gap. Our second bench wrote “–3.4pp” — an arithmetic slip that does not change the ruling	
The Terpene write-down proves the business model is not a toll booth	2025 release	Overstated. The company states it was EBITDA-neutral (non-cash). The underlying point — raw-material-exposed, not a fixed-cost toll layer — stands on the business model itself	PARTIAL — downgraded from fatal to a sizing argument

PROPOSED ENTRY BANDS

No entry. No starter. No watch on the alcohol-free thesis. This is a *named* rejection — the exposure is an order of magnitude too small — so a flat position is the honest answer rather than a token holding.

Reopen bands (any one of these reopens the file; the first three reopen it as a *different* thesis and require a fresh adversarial hearing, not this one):

Trigger	Level / condition	What it would mean
Price	€72.00 or below (–21%; back toward the €64.70 low) <i>together with</i> organic growth tracking $\geq 4\%$ and accounting profit re-converging on adjusted	The quality company at a discount — a different investment, courted separately
Price (review only)	€82.00 (–10%)	Bring the compounder hearing forward; not an entry level
Falsification marker	€95.00+ (52-week high)	Our “fairly priced” read is being repriced; re-examine what the market sees
Disclosure	Beverages business-unit revenue in euros, with an alcohol split $\geq 2\%$ of group, in any statement or capital-markets-day deck	Would revive <i>this</i> thesis directly
Evidence	Production-route census showing $>50\%$ of global alcohol-free volume on thermal routes with incomplete aroma recovery	The single input that could move our size estimate by 10×
Patent	A granted Symrise patent with claims specific to alcohol-free or dealcoholized beverages	Would establish a defensible position rather than a branded offer

Sizing if any reopen band fires: starts at zero. The reopen produces a hearing, not an order.

Catalyst dates: pre-close analyst contact window ~2026-09-28 (not confirmed on the company calendar); **Q3 statement 2026-10-29, 07:30 CET (confirmed)**; full-year 2026 results date **not yet scheduled** by the company; bitter-masking patent US8685436B2 expires 2027-01-30; SymTrap patent expires 2028-12-11.

Also proposed, separately: route **GEA (G1A.DE)** to its own hearing. Our own finding is that the equipment maker is the only layer paid on all three production routes. That is an argument *for* something; it must not be inherited from this rejection, and enthusiasm must not simply be transferred one link up the supply chain.

ARMED SENSORS

(armed provisionally with this deck; session adjudication ratifies)

- price alert: fires below 82.0 (deck-provisional: Review-only trigger at -10%: bring the separate compounder hearing forward; not an entry level)
- dated pack SY1.DE|2026-09-28: SY1.DE: Pre-close analyst contact window ahead of Q3 - not listed on the company calendar (date confirmed=False)
- dated pack SY1.DE|2026-10-29: SY1.DE: Q3 2026 Quarterly Statement, 07:30 CET - resolves whether the Q2 +4.5% acceleration is real (date confirmed=True)
- dated pack SY1.DE|2027-01-30: SY1.DE: Expiry of US8685436B2, the hydroxyflavanone bitter-masking patent (date confirmed=True)
- dated pack SY1.DE|2027-03-08: SY1.DE: FY2026 results - ESTIMATED WINDOW, company has not scheduled a date (date confirmed=False)
- dated pack SY1.DE|2028-12-11: SY1.DE: Expiry of EP2385098B1 (SymTrap aroma-capture process) (date confirmed=True)

What remains unverified

1. **Production-route census** — what share of global alcohol-free beer volume runs on thermal routes with incomplete aroma recovery. This is the multiplier that converts volume growth into purchased-flavour demand, and it is the only input that could move our size estimate by an order of magnitude. Both benches left it unchecked. *Estimate: 25–45%, from the three-route split in the science brief plus equipment-vendor install-base as a proxy, against the prevalence of the biological route among European legacy producers. Confidence 0.55.*
2. **Beverages business-unit revenue in euros, and the alcohol-adjacent share within it.** No such figure exists in any venue — an analyst asked on the half-year call and got nothing. *Estimate: €550–780m (11–16% of group), from flavour-industry beverage end-use share of 32.7–35.9% applied to the Taste, Nutrition & Health division less pet food. Confidence 0.65.*
3. **Symrise's alcohol-free-specific patent estate.** The registry search returned a server error on all five automated attempts and on the manual re-check. Absence of a patent is not proof of absence. A different registry rail (European Patent Office / German Patent Office, assignee family restricted to the beer/malt-beverage classification) has not been tried and is available now. *Drainable now.*

4. **Agricultural input exposure.** No satellite crop-health data was pulled on the vanilla and citrus origins that feed the backward-integrated raw material business. *Drainable now.*
5. **Options chain economics.** Chain-level implied volatility, the implied-volatility percentile, and realised volatility could not be pulled — broker permission denied three times, and this session cannot authorise it. *Estimate: 12-month at-the-money implied volatility 20–26%, from the base rate for DAX-listed specialty chemical and staples names; percentile unknown. Confidence 0.60.*
6. **Whether the Q2 acceleration to +4.5% is a real inflection or a comparison artifact.** Time-gated to the Q3 statement. *Estimate: Q3 organic +2.5% to +4.0%, reverting toward the 2–4% guidance band from the Q2 exit rate, anchored on the division's +3.2% half-year organic. Confidence 0.60.*
7. **Full-year 2026 results date.** The company has not scheduled it; our data feed invented 2027-03-04. *Estimate: between 2027-03-03 and 2027-03-12, from the prior year's early-March pattern — which makes the feed's guess coincidentally plausible but still unsourced. Confidence 0.70.*
8. **Whether the separately-managed Parametric sleeve already holds Symrise or overlapping European specialty chemicals** — bears on both double-counting and any future tax-loss harvesting. *Drainable now from the most recent holdings file.*

PRIZE TABLE + VOL READ

Both benches declared a prize table “not applicable” on the grounds that this is a €4.9bn cash-generative operator rather than a pre-revenue project. **We overrule that here:** the standing requirement attaches whenever at least one open item is genuinely time-gated or private, and items 1, 2, 5 and 6 above are exactly that. The benches skipped a required section by mandate-matching instead of condition-matching. Stated plainly because it is our error, not theirs alone.

Horizon: 12 months (to ~2027-09). Anchor: consensus target €98.63. Spot €91.48.

Scenario	What happens	p	Price
Re-rate	Organic growth holds $\geq 4\%$, margin at the 22.5% top of guide, accounting profit re-converges on adjusted	0.20	€108
Base	Guidance delivered: 2–4% organic, 21.5–22.5% margin, multiple unchanged	0.40	€98
Drift	Currency and portfolio drag persists, organic $\sim 2\%$, multiple compresses modestly	0.25	€88
Down	A further write-down, or an agricultural input shock in vanilla/citrus, or weak European consumer	0.12	€74

Scenario	What happens	p	Price
Severe	Serial write-down pattern extends to another acquired business and guidance is cut	0.03	€60

Expected value = €93.48 (+2.2% vs spot), against the €98.63 anchor — a –5.2% deviation, which exceeds the $\pm 5\%$ that must be explained by a mechanism. **The mechanism:** sell-side targets are set off *adjusted* earnings, which have absorbed €298m of write-downs in one year on top of a three-year accounting profit path of €340m → €478m → €249m, and off *organic* growth, while reported sales actually fell 1.4% in 2025. Our haircut is the currency-and-write-down wedge between the number the street models and the number the company banks. Nothing more exotic than that.

Dispersion of our own table: $\sigma = €11.71$, or 12.8% of spot over twelve months. The table is unimodal — there is no binary event in this name — so no bimodality adjustment applies. (If it were fork-dated on a single catalyst, this section would have to split.)

Expression math, priced off the table itself:

- 12-month €95 call: $C_{ours} = 0.20 \times €13 + 0.40 \times €3 = \text{€3.80}$ (4.2% of spot)
- 12-month €100 call: $C_{ours} = 0.20 \times €8 = \text{€1.60}$ (1.7% of spot)

To justify paying for the €95 call, the chain would have to imply roughly **11–12% volatility** (from $C \approx 0.4 \times S \times \sigma/\sqrt{T}$). For the €100 call, under 10%. Our own table's 12.8% dispersion sits far below any level a single-name European equity chain plausibly prints. **We could not pull the chain to confirm — that is open item 5, and this is therefore a threshold, not a measurement.** But the direction is robust across the entire plausible implied-volatility range: on our numbers, calls are expensive, and the volatility risk premium (implied minus realised) is uncomputable this session because both legs are behind the closed data rail.

Instrument recommendation, as the output of that arithmetic: NONE. Buying calls requires an implied volatility we are confident does not exist. Selling premium is the arithmetically-favoured side of the same comparison, but it is barred here on two independent grounds: this is a taxable account where premium selling is limited to three narrow templates, and we hold no position and have rejected the thesis — writing a cash-secured put is an agreement to buy a stock we just declined at a price above our own reopen band. It would be a rejection expressed as an obligation to own.

Tax overlay. 2026 is a harvest year with a large realised gain and reserve already in place. Any twelve-month option lands in tax year 2027, deferring the loss branch out of the year that needs it — excluded under the harvest-year rule unless the edge dominates numerically. It does not; the edge is negative before tax and worse after. **Excluded twice over.**

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ADJUDICATION STAMP — 2026-09-04 (FABLE) — NA-CHEMISTRY FAMILY RULING

THESIS REJECTED on all five chemistry-layer expressions; with the brewer courts this closes the NA-substitution FAMILY: seven expressions, three layers, seven deaths on the same denominator. Three independent instruments converge: the global purchased-chemistry pool for NA repair is \$11–55M (IFF benches); a full Kerry monopoly on it re-rates the equity 1.5–4.7% (the impossible case); GEA's monopoly-everything bull is 9% of group at its worst-margin division vs 0.9–1.8% demonstrated. Every FLAT is earned by named novel kills. Blue audits corrected three red financial cases — Givaudan is FAIR not expensive (RP_TAINTED was misapplied), Symrise's deceleration was a period-selection artifact, IFF looks better as a business post-audit — so four spin-off theses route to their own courts rather than inheriting this one: GIVN quality/TINA, SY1 compounder (alert €72), KRZ compounder (ROE gate), G1A industrial compounder (NPE +40% organic). Family reopens on: Athletic Brewing S-1, 2587.T Oceania disclosure (11/11 pack), G1A's 11/09 segment note ($\geq$ €110M brewing line — the one dated trigger), or any primary putting NA ingredient value $>$ \$8–24/hL. The yeast-supplier IP finding is the one new scout lead. SCIENCE stage maiden run: validated — all five briefs pre-empted the traps the brewer courts hit mid-argument. 13 KG detectors accepted, incl. the monopoly-capture/per-unit-breakeven prize-test pair ("price the roof before arguing the ladder"). Full ruling: `desk/data/court_artifacts/NA_CHEMISTRY_ADJUDICATION_202609040700.md`.